Mentoring Individuals in Their Practice: Inquiry and "Vipassana Out Loud," Part Two

MINDFULNESS MEDITATION TEACHER CERTIFICATION PROGRAM

Vipassana Out Loud

This simplified* version of "Vipassana Out Loud" is a hands-on way of helping the student deepen their skill in meditation practice. The student is encouraged to notice and name out loud whatever is prominent in their experience, and then to "be with" or allow what they are noticing.

If a student is encountering a challenging situation, set the groundwork for this guided practice by first seeking clarification about what they are experiencing.

Before beginning any experiential practice, ask if the student wants to do a guided mindfulness meditation. Let them know that they are free to stop at any time, particularly if it feels in any way overwhelming.

Begin by offering brief guidance to help the person arrive in the present moment. Invite them to keep their attention inward, and softly name (just a few words at a time) whatever is most predominant. You might ask them,

"What are you aware of right now?" or
"What most wants your attention?"

When something is named (heart racing, tightness in chest, thoughts about doing it right, sadness) you might further engage their attention by asking:

"Where do you feel this?" or
"What is the felt sense of this?" or
"What does this feel like?"

After questions that invite recognition and contact with the experience, then encourage the person to "be with." There are a number of ways of suggesting this—find the way of phrasing that feels most natural to you:

"Can you allow the feelings of a racing heart?"
"You might pause and simply allow the tightness."
"Taking some moments, sensing what is it like to be with the sadness."

*Note: This has been described as a simplified version of "Vipassana Out Loud" because it focuses primarily on the questions—"What are you aware of?" (Where do you feel this? What does it feel like?) and "Can you be with this?" As you become more experienced guiding this process, there are many other possible questions—"What are you believing?" "What does that part of you need?"—as well as guidance in offering self-compassion and forgiveness.

After some moments of pausing, or if you notice some shift in the person's expression, you might ask,

"What are you aware of now?" or
"What are you noticing now?"

And after they name their experience, again include follow-up refining questions (where, what is the felt sense, what does this feel like) and then invite them to "be with."

If the person is in a rhythm of naming and allowing, you don't need to invite the "being with." But if there's a long pause, it is helpful to check in. Ask:

"And now … what are you aware of?" or
"What are you noticing now?"

This movement between naming and "being with" continues until the student is offering a stable, clear, open and gentle attention to the changing flow of their experience. It is this shift in how they are relating (from "reacting to" to being "present with") that is the gift of mindfulness, and the hallmark of awakening and freedom.

You might run out of time before the student has come into wise relationship with what is arising. They might even be feeling something new that is difficult. That's OK! Unless they've tapped into trauma, you and they can trust that any effort towards mindful presence serves healing and freedom.

Before ending the session, in whatever way feels genuine, honor the person's effort. It might be an acknowledgment of their courage, their willingness, their capacity to be mindful of what was happening. Let them feel your trust in what is unfolding, your confidence in the awakening that is happening and possible.

The most important thing is that the person feels a growing trust in their capacity to deepen their attention, be intimate with their inner life, and awaken.

SOME NAVIGATIONAL GUIDELINES

If you sense it's difficult for the student to "be with," you can offer some supportive skillful means:

"You might breathe with the experience, letting the breath be felt directly in that area of difficulty."
"Can you let this float in awareness?"
"Can you soften around, feel space around?"
"What happens if you broaden the field of attention to include sound, space?"
"What happens if you regard with a kind, gentle attention?"

If there is a lot of thinking, you might guide them in noting thoughts, and then bringing a full attention to the body to discover what is happening in the present moment. Emphasize attention to the throat, chest and belly. In general, it is helpful to periodically remind the person to notice what is happening in their body.

If the person says "I can't feel anything in my body," reassure them that this is very common, and that they will increase mindfulness of the body through more regularly directing a gentle receptive attention to the body, and through formal practice with body scans.

Also, remember that often people don't recognize certain feelings (numbness, heaviness, thickness) as feelings. If they say "All I feel is numbness," you can ask,

"Where do you feel this?" and
"What does numbness feel like … please tell me more."

And then continue with the meditation by inviting them to be with what they are experiencing.

If there's a lot going on for the person, including confusion or seemingly conflicting feelings, it can be helpful to ask (as at the beginning):

"What most wants your attention right now?"

When you ask, you might suggest they listen to their body and heart.

If the person lets you know that the experience is "too much," or if you see signs of overwhelm or trauma, encourage them to open their eyes, ground themselves and reconnect with whatever provides safety and increased ease. (Refer to Trauma and Strong Fear handouts #1 and #2.)

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Vipassana Out Loud

TWO DYAD PRACTICES

1. In pairs, one person will be speaking and the other will be listening silently. The person speaking will be repeatedly saying "I am aware of … " and filling in the blank.

Then you will switch roles. (This exercise will be teacher-led.)

2. Same pair: Person A will be in the role of student and person B will be in the role of a teacher who is guiding A in Vipassana Out Loud (refer to handout) (10 minutes).

Share informally about the experience (5 minutes), then switch.